

Aestheticism

Overview

Aestheticism was an artistic and literary movement born in England in the second half of the 19th century. It was a reaction against the values of Victorian society, which saw art as something useful — a way to teach moral lessons or improve people. The Aestheticists disagreed completely. Their main idea is expressed in the motto "**Art for Art's Sake**" (*l'art pour l'art*): art exists only to be beautiful. It does not need to have a moral message or a practical purpose.

Key Principles

For the Aestheticists, the job of the artist was to feel and express sensations. Art was meant to give pleasure to the senses, not to teach or to judge. Because of this, art had to be kept completely separate from politics, religion, and social problems. Beauty was the only thing that mattered in art.

Walter Pater

The most important thinker of Aestheticism in England was **Walter Pater**. He did not believe in religion, and he thought that art was the only real and certain thing in life. For Pater, the goal of life was to have as many strong and beautiful experiences as possible. Art was the best way to do this, because it can take a single moment and keep it alive forever. He believed that every person should try to live their life like a work of art. His ideas had a great influence on many writers of the time.

Oscar Wilde and the Dandy

The most famous person connected to Aestheticism is **Oscar Wilde**. He used Pater's ideas in his own life and writing. Wilde said that **life imitates art** — the opposite of what most people believed. This means that the way we see and live reality is influenced by art, not the other way around.

Wilde also became known as a **dandy**: someone who puts elegance, good taste, and beauty at the centre of their life. The dandy did not have to come from a noble family, but lived with luxury and style, often using money from family inheritance. The dandy rejected the typical values of the middle class — such as hard work and following the rules — and chose instead to live for beauty and pleasure.